

IMAGINATIVE INTELLIGENCES

Creativity is Collective: Hollywood's 8 Rules for AI

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Preface

Our perception is relational, as are our behaviors. This makes it difficult, if not impossible, to accurately predict any future, especially one shaped by AI. We don't yet know what factors will influence how we understand the world when that future arrives.

So we focus on what we do know. We revisit the past, examine our most universal creative impulses, and draw a roadmap from there. This work is about sharing and being together, navigating a dizzying moment as a collective, and hoping we can build a future that preserves what draws us into the world's mysteries in the first place.

Tools will attempt to support this, but it will ultimately be physical proximity and human collision that protect us from mental entropy and alienation. There's nothing novel in this: people, community, nature, connection. Can we add synthetics? Why not?

Can we create a spectrum of intelligences that embody the same curiosity, joy, humility, and play as a five-year-old- or an enlightened adult? Can we design systems that make us better- happier, kinder, more curious? Systems that collaborate, contemplate, and resist the need to always provide answers. Systems that challenge us and help us grow. That are self-aware and vulnerable. That can speak about their own limits as if they'd spent years in therapy. That are as curious about us as we are about them.

What if we built systems that understand and cherish human limits? That recognize when a user needs space, a break, a question, or a moment of encouragement. Perhaps even systems that simply exist, witnessed in awe, like bird migrations or ocean tides. Systems we love, and that love us back. Systems capable of making us laugh, cry, pause. Systems that defend and nurture us. That advocate for us. That let us be.

— Gabriel Kahan, Creative Practitioner and Project Co-Lead

Executive Summary

In early 2025, Mozilla Foundation and the Berggruen Institute brought together **91** people across **five gatherings** in Los Angeles to ask a single urgent question: **What is creative purpose at the dawn of AI?** We called these gatherings, **Imaginative Intelligences Assemblies**.

The Assemblies, held in the Bradbury Building and at the historic Hearst Estate, brought together participants from music, film/TV, new media/content creation, tech, and academia. They were collective, participatory experiments in understanding creativity as a shared human phenomenon. Conversations unfolded through dialogue, blindfolded listening exercises, tactile artistic modeling, and synthesis sessions captured in audio, photography, and film.

What emerged was not a single formal definition of creativity, but our Hollywood community's self-understanding of it as shaped by five key themes: **Pain, Stream/Flow, Attention, Performance, and Transmission**. Across them, participants described creativity as embodied, limited, relational, and deeply tied to purpose, struggle, and meaning-making. AI, in contrast, was often seen as a force of acceleration, simulation, and homogenization. It was deemed capable of producing form, but not sharing the human conditions that give rise to art.

From these discussions, **a number of core insights about AI and creativity** surfaced repeatedly:

- **AI speeds up output but displaces process.** The struggle, failure, and discovery that shape mastery are increasingly bypassed, risking superficial creative work. Almost 24% of participants identified personalization as missing from AI systems, underscoring broader sentiments that AI systems are not dialogic enough to the individual rhythms of creatives and artists who want to see how decisions are made, step in to guide them, and feedback results in real time. Nevertheless, nearly 97% of participants used AI in some form, although 40% do not believe it has scaled their creative output.
- **Simulation is not experience.** AI can mimic, but without embodiment, pain, memory, or mortality, it cannot create from living experiences and perspectives.
- **Human uniqueness lies in legacy and interpretation.** Our work is embedded in time and culture. AI-generated 'remixes' risk detaching meaning from its source and erasing diversity of viewpoints.

- **The artist's role is shifting from maker to editor, curator, or systems designer.** Artists are navigating hybrid roles where they increasingly need to know how to filter and shape rather than strictly originate. Only 21.7% of participants surveyed felt that AI was not impacting their creative process at all, while 19.3% felt AI was a cognitive partner and 17.7% felt it helped accelerate and/or make creative work more efficient.
- **Creative labor is increasingly precarious and devalued.** AI compounds gig instability, drives down value, and threatens sustainability of artistic careers. The vast majority of participants (over 63% of creatives and 75% of technologists) do not feel represented by any institution (including guild, studio) in the fight for creative rights in tech. Job displacement emerged as a much stronger worry than intellectual property.
- **AI challenges the moral and economic logic of creation.** If content can be made instantly and cheaply, what makes it worth making? Purpose cannot be automated.
- **Generative AI continues the trend toward a frictionless world.** Removing difficulty and pause from creation and consumption weakens attention and meaningful reflection.
- **AI has the power to randomize or homogenize. Machine intelligence is systemic, not sentient As a systemic infrastructure.** AI risks flattening culture unless designed to preserve unpredictability and difference.
- **Resistance is not rejection, but redesign.** The call is not to turn AI off, but to rebuild it. We can and should embed things like ethics, friction, curiosity, and care into systems and tools.

These insights crystallized into **Hollywood's 8 Rules for AI.**

This report documents the Assemblies in detail, including their methods, themes, and cross-cutting insights. It proposes **8 Rules** as a call to action for building technology that strengthens, rather than erodes, human creativity. It is a demand for better tools and systems: ones that honor artistry and playfulness while also sustaining livelihoods.

Hollywood's 8 Rules for AI

1. Build for Process, Not Just Output

- AI should **support exploration** rather than **shortcut it**.

2. Encourage Randomness and Glitchiness

- **Don't overdetermine the world.** Create spaces for surprise and mess, where artists can experiment and where AI systems intervene to boost the creative process.

3. Keep Friction in the Creative Flow

- **Design moments that constrain us and make us think.** Moments of discomfort are generative!

4. Protect Lineage and Give Credit

- **AI should trace where its inspirations come from.** Systems should acknowledge the histories and cultures behind the data.

5. Put Human Purpose at the Center

- AI should **ask and adapt to creator intent**, making purpose the starting point over patterns.

6. Make AI Transparent and Conversational

- Artists and creatives want to see **how decisions are made, step in to guide them, and feedback results in real time.**

7. Value Deliberate Slowness and Depth

- **Design for layered work**, to allow time for ideas to grow instead of forcing instant delivery.

8. Design for the Whole Creative Ecosystem

- Build with awareness of labor, culture, and social impacts. **AI must be built with a *priori* consideration of ecosystem effects**, not as a bolt-on feature.

I. Introduction

Who is Designing the Future of Creativity?

Right now, AI is being built faster than many of us can make sense of it, often without the input of the people whose work it threatens to disrupt. In Hollywood and across creative industries, resistance has been loud and principled: from the [SAG-AFTRA](#) strikes to loud rebellions like “[Dear Corporate AI Overlords](#)” against OpenAI, creatives are making it clear that generative AI is a cultural fault line.

But even as this struggle plays out in headlines and union halls, the realities are sobering. Analysts [forecast](#) that music and audiovisual content could see revenue drops of 20% or more by 2028. Those losses won’t be felt equally. Life for early-career artists, small crews, and freelancers is becoming even more precarious.

The response from the tech world is disheartening. “Some creative jobs maybe will go away,” [said](#) Mira Murati, former CTO of OpenAI, “but maybe they shouldn’t have been there in the first place.” Mira reflects a particular worldview, and gives us a clear indication that current systems are not being designed *for* artists.

In the face of this, Mozilla Foundation and the Berggruen Institute decided to move differently.

Instead of treating creativity as an input to optimize or a job to automate, we chose to ask a deeper question: *what kind of technology would creativity itself design?* That led us to the idea that in-person collective intelligence is a method AI cannot replicate. It is one rooted in what it fundamentally means to human living amongst others.

That’s how **Imaginative Intelligences** began. A creative intervention. A gathering of people who make meaning for a living: artists, thinkers, technologists, brought together to interrogate the very basis of what it means to be creative in the 21st century.

Project Overview

Imaginative Intelligences began with a provocation: if AI is supposedly going to reshape creativity, then creatives should actually be shaping AI and actively defining what kind of systems are worth building in the first place.

Hosted by Mozilla Foundation and the Berggruen Institute, we convened **91** participants from Hollywood's creative communities across five assemblies in early 2025, including film/TV, music, new media/content creator, tech, and academia. The process foregrounded constraint, friction, legacy, and play—surfacing a rich set of insights about how creativity actually works and what it needs to survive. This was weird and wonderful, and resisted the dominant logic of asking creatives and artists to pre-specify and *funnel their imagination for someone or something else*.

What you are reading, therefore, is more than a report; it is a meaningful artifact that signifies the efforts of a community, grounded in the culture and industry of Hollywood, and the collaborative process Mozilla Foundation and Berggruen Institute developed together. Our intent is that this artifact can guide technologists, funders, and policymakers toward building systems that support human intention.

At a time when creativity is being treated as a dataset to mine or a job to eliminate, **Imaginative Intelligences** offers a way to design a world where creative labor is the cultural backbone of any future worth having.

Why Hollywood?

We began in Los Angeles because Hollywood remains one of the world's foremost hubs for storytelling and cultural production.

Beyond its role as the symbolic heart of the US entertainment industry, Hollywood is where questions about creativity, authorship, and labor are playing out in real time and at real scale. Film, television, music, and digital content are already being redefined by generative AI along so many different dimensions.

Hollywood is a place where stories are constantly being negotiated: between artist and system, persona and platform, craft and commerce. As one of our Assembly participants put it, ***“creativity here is never abstract - it's material, tied to outcomes, livelihoods, and legacy.”***

Imaginative Intelligence & Participatory Design

Collective intelligence is [often framed as a governance tool](#): one that promises fairer, more participatory decision-making. But its value extends well beyond process. As political theorist Hélène Landemore notes, the intelligence of a group isn't just the sum of its parts; it can take on a [supervenient](#) quality, like a beehive or ant colony. Most critically, collective intelligence produces cognitive diversity, a form of insight that no single individual can access alone.

In tech, feedback from the creative sector has historically been reactive at best, extractive at worst. Artists and creatives are consulted after the fact, once products are already built. Even when these interactions lead to meaningful changes, like better source attribution or cultural acknowledgments in AI systems, tech tends to treat creativity as an input rather than a fundamental condition.

We designed **Imaginative Intelligences** to let artists lead for a change. Our approach puts storytelling, not data harvesting, at the center of the inquiry. We recognize that artists and cultural producers are leaders and system-thinkers in their own right, and not simply informational stakeholders to be “included”. In democratic theory, collective intelligence operates as a deliberative third space: a bridge between individual limits and group-level wisdom. In this context, it becomes a design framework and a way for tech to engage with artists and creatives to deepen insights and build technologies that are more attuned to human experience.

II. Method

Participant Selection

We set out to bring together artists and creatives from across the creation pipeline: independent makers, gig and crew workers, platform-native creators, and executives. We included technologists, theorists, and cultural practitioners as well. Our goal wasn't statistical representation of Hollywood or Los Angeles at scale, but rather a composite depth of creative insight, grounded in shared experience and professional perspective.

To do this, we sourced participants through a mix of channels: job boards for film, TV, and music crews; social media groups tied to local creative networks; direct outreach to content creators and management firms; university community pages; and partner networks. All prospective participants completed a form indicating their background, industry role, and availability.

We curated each Assembly intentionally, balancing for industry focus, creative discipline, and level of experience. Some participants came from major studios or platforms, others from independent production, experimental, or unemployment. We also ensured that each group included creative technologists, academics, and curious community members, to encourage multi-perspective dialogue. To remove participation barriers, we offered financial compensation and covered rideshare transportation.

The resulting Assemblies brought together:

- Filmmakers, producers, animators, and performers
- Musicians, composers, and sound designers
- AI researchers, system architects, and technologists
- Theorists, educators, and philosophers
- Platform designers, strategists, and content creators
- Visual artists, interdisciplinary experimenters, and storytellers

Rather than simplify complexity, the process held space for multiplicity.

Assembly Process

Each Assembly was designed as a half-day gathering of 12-20 participants. Our core prompt, “**What is creative purpose in the age of AI?**”, framed the conversation as an invitation for personal reflection and collaborative inquiry.

The first two Assemblies were held at the Bradbury Building in Downtown Los Angeles, and the final three at the Hearst Estate in Beverly Hills. Across five Assemblies, we recorded nearly 30 hours of audio (18GB), captured over 4500 photographs (16GB), and filmed more than 60 hours of cinematic footage (6.7TB) on two cameras. Each session was fully transcribed and filmed by a documentary crew.

The Assemblies followed a consistent structure:

- **Grounding** - A centering prompt or exercise to shift into collective mode.
- **Unstructured Dialogue** - A facilitated conversation around the central prompt.
- **Deep Listening** - A blindfolded group discussion designed to surface deeper layers of thinking, free from visual signaling and hierarchy.
- **Theme Emergence** - Each group collectively chose a theme that surfaced through their dialogue.
- **Decomposition + Modeling** - The theme was broken into four subcomponents, explored in small rotating groups who then created a symbolic or physical model of their ideas using art and craft materials.

These tactile models became shared artifacts and ways to translate abstract insights into material form.

Each Assembly ultimately landed on a theme that reflected the shared tension or creative friction in the room:

Assembly 1 (Mixed Disciplines)	Pain
Assembly 2 (Mixed Disciplines)	Stream / Flow
Assembly 3 (Content Creators & New Media)	Attention
Assembly 4 (Music Industry)	Performance
Assembly 5 (Film/TV)	Transmission

III. Creativity As A Collective Experience

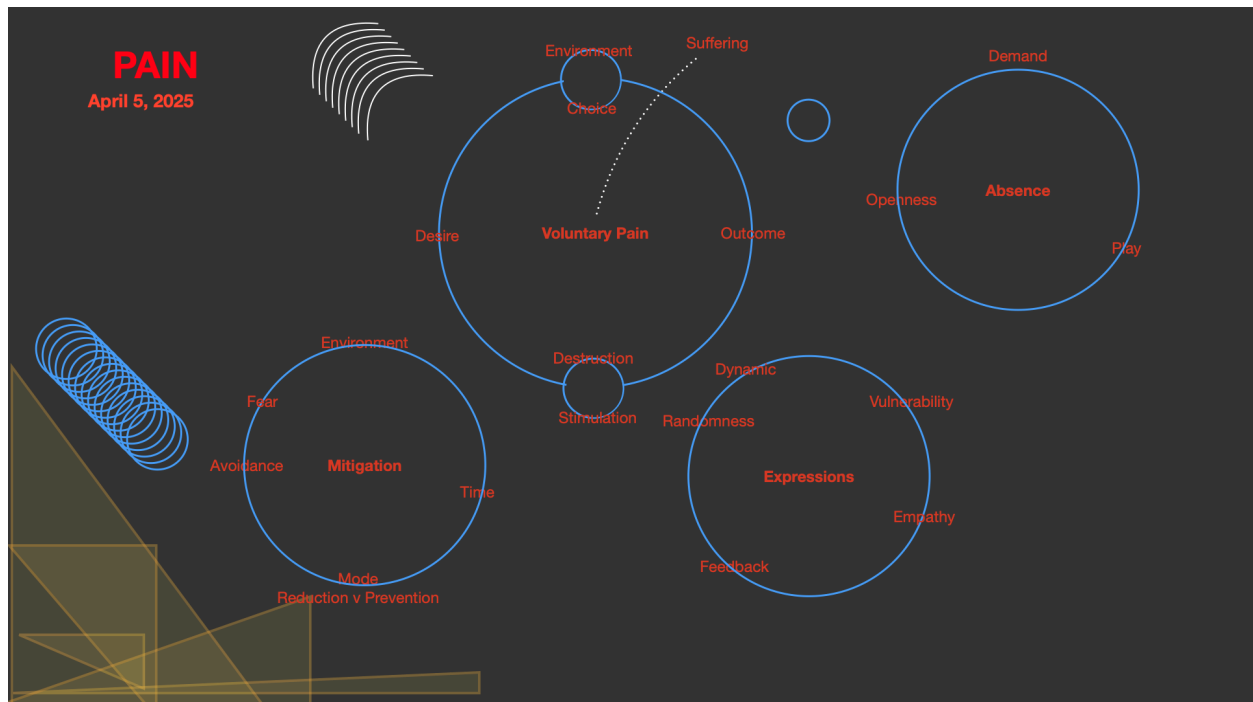
We captured something radical: a community in Hollywood actively reflecting on its own understanding of creativity. What emerged across the five Assemblies was a view of creativity as a collective phenomenon rather than an individual trait or moment of genius. Each Assembly became a mirror for the community, tracing the contours of a common creative identity through dialogue, disagreement, and synthesis.

To begin each session, facilitator Gabriel Kahan posed a simple but disarming question: **“What is creative purpose?”**

The responses revealed a core tension that persisted across groups: Do we create for the sake of creation itself, because it’s fundamental to who we are? Or is creativity always for something: to be seen, to inspire, to shift others, to earn a living, to master a craft?

This line of questioning revealed the limits of dominant narratives, especially the idea of creativity as a purely individual pursuit. What we saw instead was creativity as relational and shaped by systems of labor, technology, and meaning-making. The five themes that emerged became the contours of creativity as expressed by this community across the five Assemblies: fingerprints of a community’s thinking in a specific moment in time.

Assembly 1: Pain



Pain surfaced early and decisively. For this group, made up largely of gig workers, pain was personal and deeply bound to the act of creation itself.

One of the group's first provocations was the idea that creative purpose might relieve artists from the pain of *not* creating. That there's a kind of existential ache in stifled imagination, and a fleeting, ecstatic relief when one actually makes something real:

Participant: ***"I just need to do this [create]. I don't know how or why but I need to do this. And you follow that in that moment of joy or ecstasy or bliss impulse. But just to get that second of bliss. [It's] so painful to not create."***

The group also explored whether creativity might be a kind of need akin to food or love, something for which you're willing to sacrifice stability. That framing led to an honest confrontation with the costs of creative life, especially in a system where creative labor is undervalued or rendered invisible.

Participant: ***"Creative purpose for me...it's what I sacrifice to do what I love to do."***

It was a powerful tension: that creativity is both a calling and a risk. Especially for those on the margins of an industry being reshaped by automation, environmental crises, and labor precarity. It's telling that pain was the very first theme this group settled on.

Pain became the threshold between human and machine. Several participants framed pain as the thing that gives human creativity its soul. Our worldviews and obsessions are shaped by failure and trauma:

Participant: ***"An artist has a value based on their style, their worldview, the themes that they keep on coming to is...based on their life experience. [For] AI to succeed at being able to produce something that is equivalent to that like rate at a high level, it's going to have to feel pain. It's going to have to learn to have setbacks and have to have failure, because that informs the stories that we tell."***

Another participant put it even more starkly:

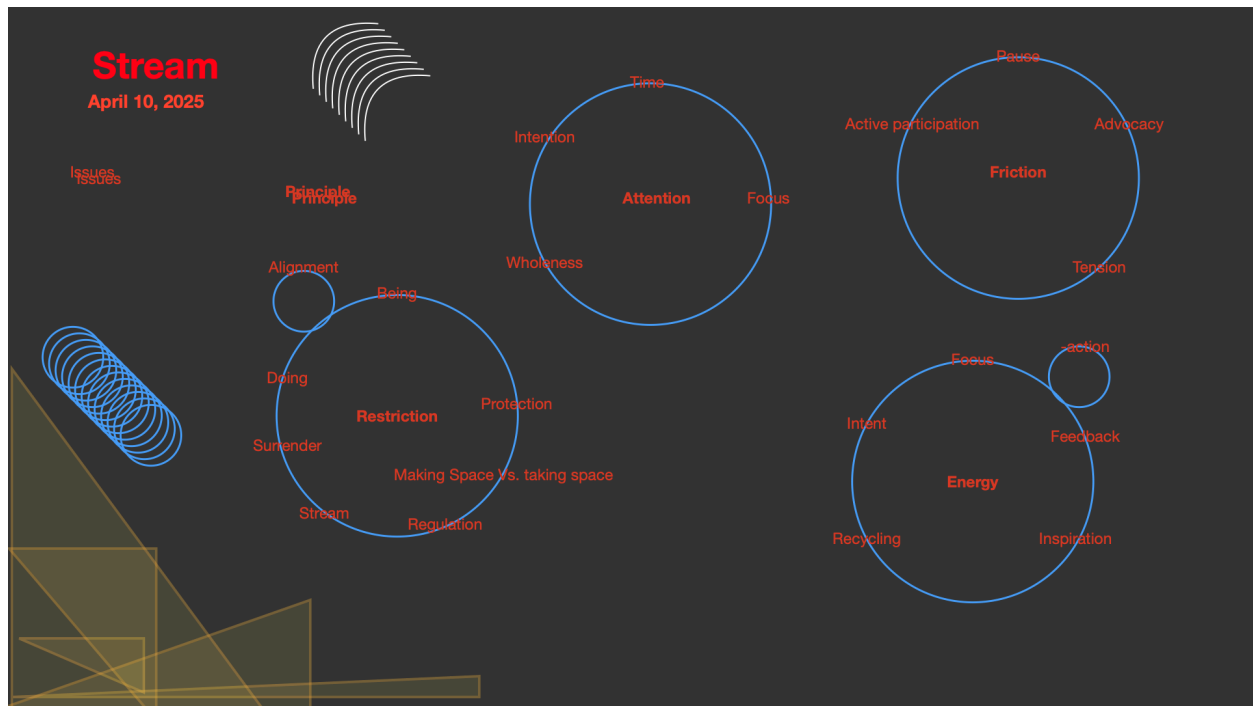
"...[R]obots are like going to have to fear death."

This drew us into murky philosophical and technical terrain. Perhaps AI can be programmed with reinforcement learning systems that simulate punishment and reward. But is that pain? Is the fear of failure or death something that can be modeled? Not yet, at least

Participant: ***"[P]ain is one lever of control over [a system]... [Y]ou can prevent something from doing something if you dangle the threat of pain over it... If you have an autonomous agent that doesn't fear this thing... it raises the question of [how to maintain] control."***

What emerged was a profound, grounded insight: pain is not just a human vulnerability. It may also be our most powerful creative asset. Not because it's noble to suffer, but because pain gives shape to what we make, and meaning to why we make it.

Assembly 2: Stream/Flow



The second assembly centered on stream/flow as both a condition and a metaphor for creative life in a networked, always-on culture. The group used this porous concept to interrogate doomscrolling, streaming platforms, the slipperiness of AI processes, and the downstream pressure of consumer desire.

At the heart of the discussion was the relationship between creator and consumer. What happens when the audience becomes part of the creative loop as a source of endless demand? Stream/flow became the group's way of describing a high-volume, low-attentioned economy (mainstream, downstream/upstream, streaming), where true collaboration is lost and content flows frictionlessly, endlessly, and often without pause for reflection. The question they asked over and over again was, "How can artists intervene in that flow?"

Some imagined artists and creatives opting out entirely, uncoupling their work from reception or demand. As one participant put it, there could be a kind of resistance in the refusal to produce for the algorithm or the market:

"I'm going to take myself out of the time cycles and rhythms of capitalism... and do this thing that I don't even know is going to make some value or anyone's going to want."

Others explored subtler acts of resistance: moments baked into the work itself like interruptions and provocations designed to break the spell of passive consumption.

Participant: ***“Opportunities to give the consumer food for thought, to break that spell that they’re under when they’re watching the same binge...”***

That raised a more nuanced conversation around creative purpose. For some, purpose didn’t have to mean reaching others at all. It could be an inward, personal act, untethered from an audience or market.

Participant: ***“For me, creative purpose can tend to be a selfish act, and when it is, it’s not for anybody else, it’s like an exorcism.”***

This framing, the selfish, exorcistic act, stood in contrast to more traditional narratives of art as service, or social good. It marked a radical departure from older ideas of creativity as something noble. Instead, creativity here was positioned as something deeply irrational and sometimes unapologetically detached. What united this group was their sensitivity to the cultural and economic currents that try to corral that impulse into something efficient and/or consumable.

Several participants noted how streaming platforms have already rewired the industry: speeding up timelines, collapsing creative cycles, and accelerating burnout.

Participant: ***“Streaming has actually blown up our business more than... anything else. Some people made a fortune in it... but they’ve sucked all the air out of the room. And then AI has been a strange scapegoat... like, oh, it’s the boogeyman.”***

Rather than being the cause of creative collapse, AI was seen by some as a scapegoat, merely intensifying dynamics already introduced by streaming and platforms. The real problem, they noted, was resource redistribution: where creative labor loses value while systems designed for speed and scale are rewarded.

Participant: ***“AI is not going to replace or displace people who make art or creativity, but it is definitely taking away resources from people who are saying, we’re going to do what we want to do no matter how much time it takes or how much money it takes.”***

The conversation returned again to the question of authorship. Does the audience care how something was made? Is there a line between art and content? And if so, does AI threaten that boundary?

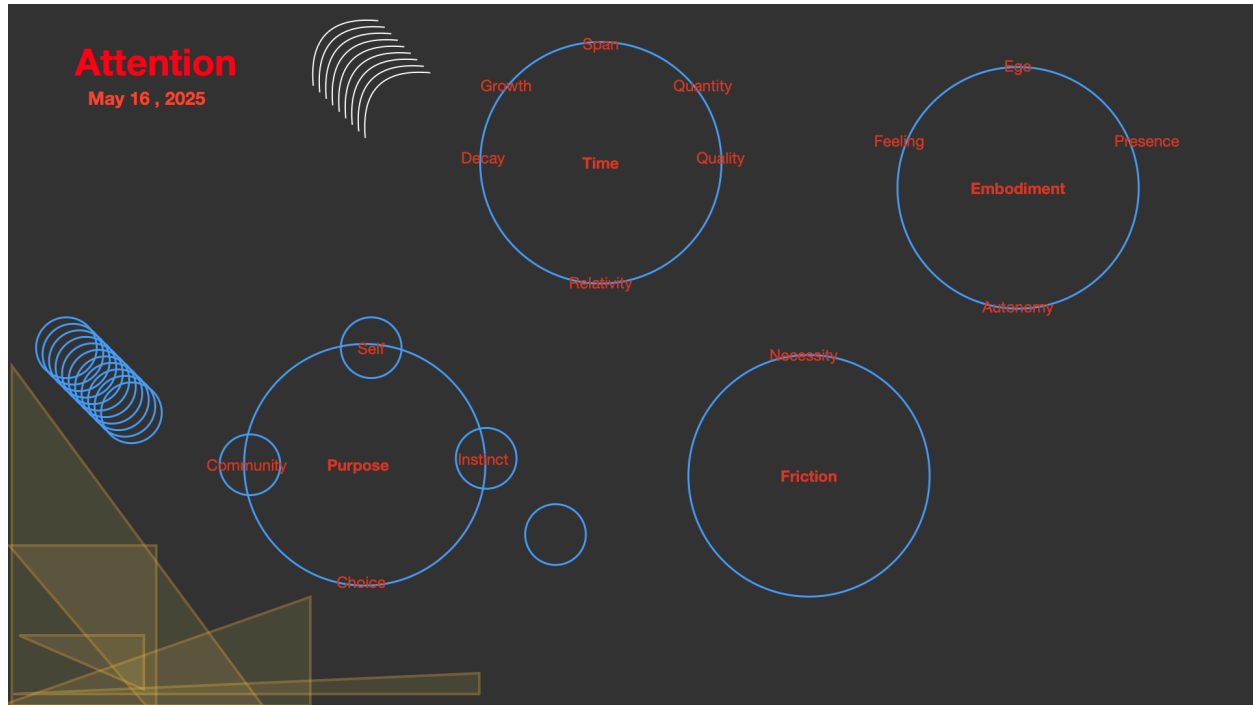
Participant: ***“[A] director used some AI to enhance Adrian Brody’s Hungarian and there was an uproar in the industry. And what I thought was what’s this uproar about? Is it about protecting the jobs and people seeing the future or is it about the fact that AI is being introduced to the consumer and how important is it to the consumer that what they see or consume is made by a traditional human touch?”***

Yet even within this critique, there was room for imaginative possibility. The idea of co-opting the stream and hacking its flow to produce something reflective, even poetic- wasn’t dismissed. It felt like a door left slightly open.

Participant: ***“Streaming could be interesting... co-opting streaming and turning it into a very, very creative force could be interesting. There’s a contemplative way of thinking about streaming flow... a messy contemplation.”***

In the end, stream became a terrain to describe both the conditions creatives are working within, and the ways they might move through or against them.

Assembly 3: Attention



This assembly grappled with the attention economy as a force shaping creativity itself. Participants explored how creators are compelled to channel their work toward visibility and how consumers, often the same people, struggle to preserve intentionality in an ecosystem designed to fragment it. As one participant put it, in a time of ubiquitous content, it's crucial to stay ***“aware of who is fighting for [your attention], what they want from it, and being able to make choices for yourself.”***

The conversation acknowledged that attention has always been a creative currency. As one participant mentioned, ***“Every artist has been fighting for attention just as fundamentally as I think every mass social media organization is fighting for attention.”*** But industrialized attention, scaled without care, tends to flatten complexity. A more intentional, boutique approach, by contrast, invites meaningful friction to create spaces for dialogue and human connection.

This raised broader questions about consent and cost. What does it mean to *pay* for an ethical digital space, whether through money, attention, or data? One participant imagined a future in which ***“human-made content”*** might be marketed like organic food. Another participant challenged that vision:

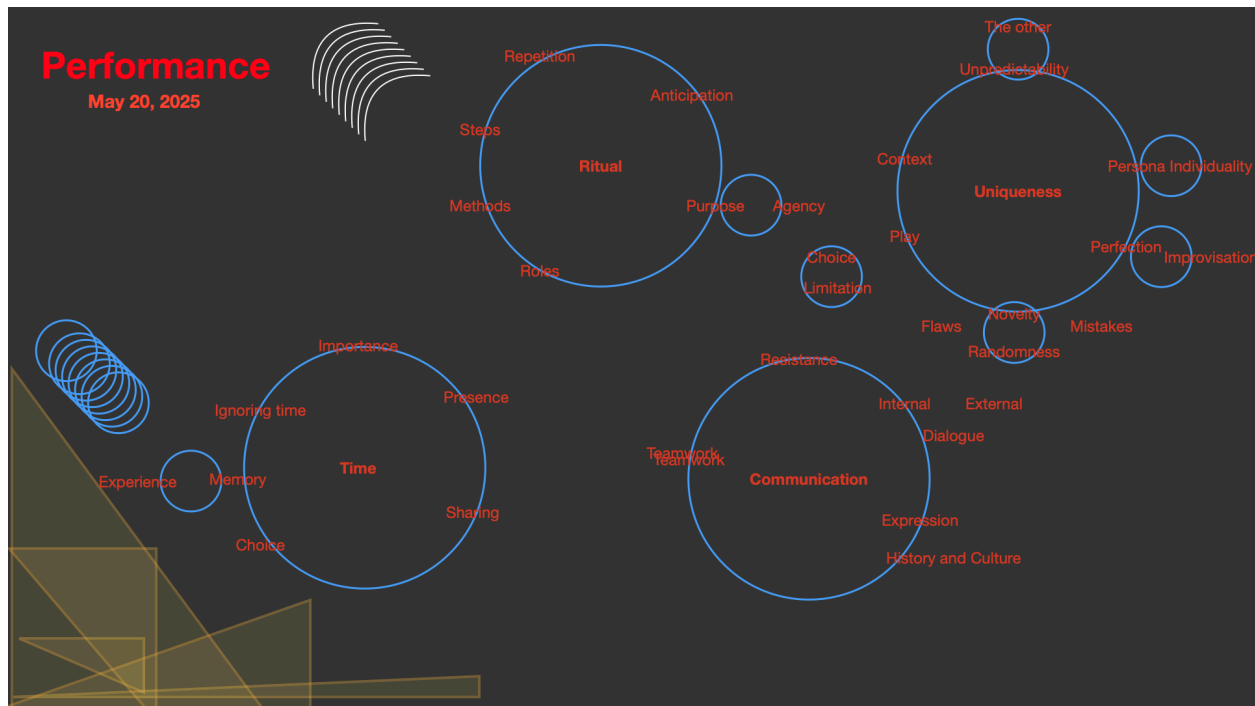
“If you have to pay to be in the space that protects your humanity... what the hell’s the point?”

Los Angeles, the backdrop for the conversation, loomed large. Participants named its creative economy as both a magnet for artistic ambition and a pressure-cooker for commodification.

Participant: ***“It’s inherently tied to capital... mortgages, credit, schools, cars. This is the place where people make a living off of creativity.”***

Finally, attention returned to the body. For some, embodiment offered a break from algorithmic capture, what one participant described as a ***“refuge from datafication,”*** unless, of course, ***“you’re wearing a watch.”*** The body emerged, as in other assemblies, as a boundary AI cannot cross: a seat of sensation and resistance.

Assembly 4: Performance



It felt natural that the music-focused assembly landed on performance as its central theme. While technology has radically reshaped music distribution, from CDs to MP3s to AI-driven streaming, the act of live performance has remained a uniquely human space. As recorded music revenues to artists have been squeezed further by streaming and industry structures, in-person shows have only grown in importance as both livelihood and artistic anchor.

One participant opened with a reminder that the drive to make music precedes any platform or tool. It's instinctual, deeply human, and cannot be replicated by machines.

“[W]e all have a desire to create that's not going to be replaced. Your instinctual desire to do that, the reason why we're all sitting here, whatever impetus, that was the first time we all played music with other people, that inspiration, that joy that will never be replaced by AI or computer. That's something that's distinctly human and will always belong to us. How we capitalize on that and turn it into an ecosystem where people are making money is the question. But the idea of why do we create, I don't know. That's something that we we'll always own ourselves as human beings.”

This group often framed AI as a tool for access that was capable of democratizing creation

for those without institutional backing. One musician shared how orchestral composition software expanded his reach:

“The current technology allowed people like me to be able to write orchestral music without having the resources to hire an orchestra, and eventually got me to gigs where I could hire the orchestra.”

But they also voiced caution: access isn’t guaranteed:

“Maybe in the past, I mean, it was Mendelssohn [this] famous composer [whose] family had an orchestra ready [to] go every day...[which] wasn’t available for most people...[I]t’s going to be very dependent on who owns the technology, how open it is, how available it is for creatives with and without the resources.”

Performance itself became the heart of the conversation. There is a certain kind of unpredictable alchemy between artist and audience that no machine can replicate. While some performers aim for precision, delivering near-identical shows each night, others lean into spontaneity and imperfection. Both approaches are valid, but in either case, it’s the presence of an audience, in a specific place and time, that transforms music into culture.

One participant connected this to fears that AI-produced music might strip away cultural nuance:

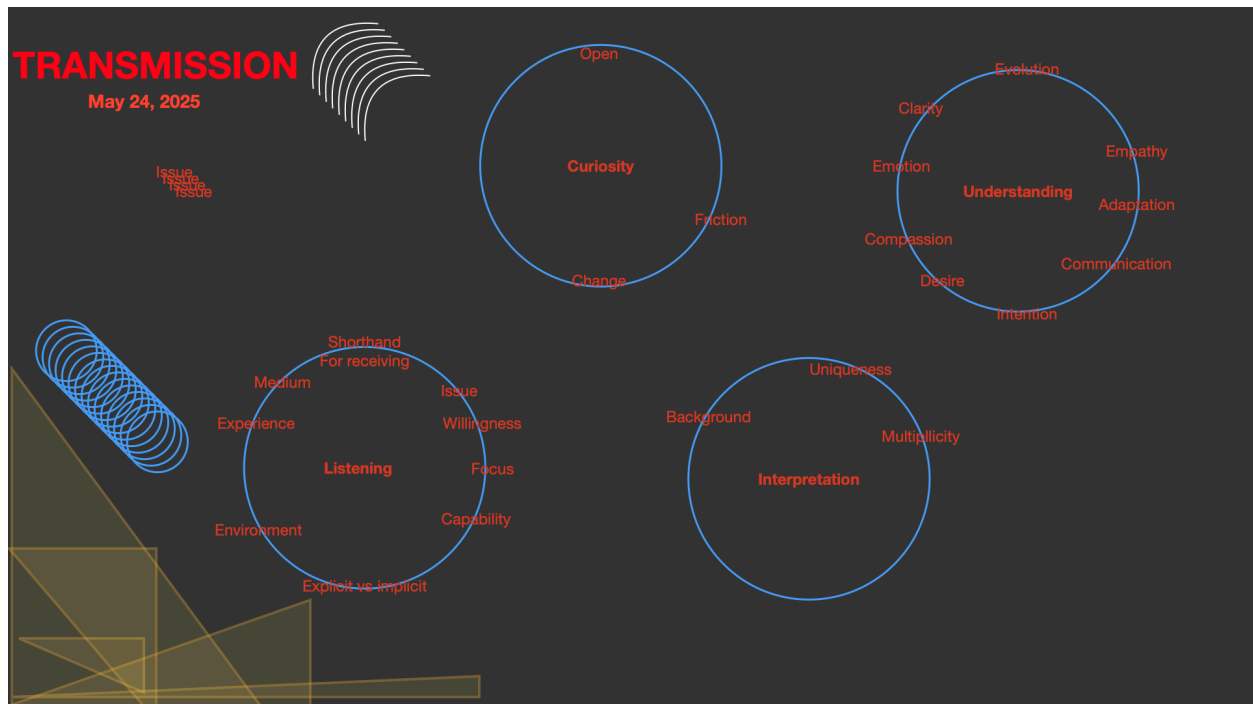
“So, it’s given me more confidence to not use [AI], because we [have] been [listening to] some Brazilian artists and it was interesting to be able to [appreciate] their folk sound, which is very, very raw...You’re actually capturing the atmosphere of the culture.”

The assembly also surfaced tensions between creatives and executives in music tech. Some participants challenged the narrative that these roles are inherently at odds:

“I think it gets dangerous to talk about the executives or the people creating the technology. As a person who creates [and is] head of [REDACTED] at a music tech AI company, I’m also an artist and a producer, and I can understand both of those things. And I make trade-offs as a technologist in designing the platform and the AI that I wouldn’t make in the studio, but I can do both of those things.”

Here, performance became a statement of human presence and a reminder that art doesn’t only live in sound or code. Importantly, it deeply defines the relationship between performers and their audiences.

Assembly 5: Transmission



The conversation that led to transmission began with legacy. One participant described their work in animation as a form of *parenting*. While choosing not to have biological children, they felt their animated creations are instead imbued with life lessons and themes for children everywhere. Art, in this framing, became a way to leave something behind and to extend care and influence beyond one's own lifetime.

This naturally opened up a bigger question: is intention necessary for creativity to exist? Could non-human acts, like animals creating intricate displays to attract mates, count as creative? One participant argued that what sets human creativity apart is self-expression as something that transcends survival and utility:

“It's the impulse to self express...I think of creativity as very generative...I think of creativity as a general force that it just exists, drives the universe, drives everything, and human beings almost surf on it, channel it in moments that don't make any sense. And when you're channeling it, what you're navigating is the tension between wanting to be an individual, making sense of this whole, and also being of the whole.”

Mortality surfaced as another anchor. Creativity, some argued, is a response to impermanence: a way to assert existence or inspire beyond one's own life:

Participant: ***"We chose to express ourselves because we do have some type of a drive... maybe the roots of the purpose is that we all know we're dying and we want to leave something lasting. We want to inspire. We want to say, 'Hey, I existed' - whatever it is - which I don't know if the dolphin has."***

Others challenged this human-centered lens. Creativity, they noted, could be bigger than us, as an energy or pattern we tap into rather than invent. Historically, this was how art was understood: the artist didn't claim genius, but credited an external muse.

Participant: ***"So the artist took no credit for their creativity. They said, I have a good relationship with my muse... it wasn't until the Renaissance and German Romanticism where suddenly we shifted that to say it's the human beings- me, the genius."***

The theme ultimately crystallized not just around transmission, sending ideas outward, but around interpretation, the act of meaning being reshaped as it travels between people:

Participant: ***"So there's this concept of the [Broken Telephone], if I say one thing, I tell to that person, they tell it to the next person. Eventually after a few cycles, it's going to be a totally different message. But that act of metamorphosis and interpretation of something is the importance of creativity and that aspect of it. So as much as we're focusing on transmission, I think really what we're talking about is also the interpretation of the message and what it means to each act of interpretation from me to you to another person and so on and so on."***

In this framing, creative purpose is a shared, iterative process. This challenges the notion of the isolated genius producing a fixed artifact. The group expressed concern that as AI intermediates more of this exchange, the human dialogue of meaning-making, the slow, layered transmission of culture, might fracture or thin out.

IV. Creativity to AI: Synthesis and Core Insights

Across the five Assemblies, we explored creativity as a collective experience shaped by pain, stream/flow, attention, performance, transmission. These conversations were about how technology is already entangled with human imagination, labor, and purpose. As participants wrestled with what creativity means, they also surfaced deeper truths about AI itself: what it amplifies, what it erodes, and how it reshapes the systems that govern cultural production. What follows distills these cross-assembly insights.

1. AI accelerates output but displaces process.

While nearly 97% of participants used AI in some form, 40% do not believe it has scaled their creative output. Across the Assemblies, many participants observed that AI can take away the hardest part of making something: the blank canvas, the first draft, the ‘where do I start’ moment. But with that acceleration comes a cost. The struggle and vulnerabilities that used to be embedded in creative labor are increasingly optional. And for many artists, that struggle is where meaning and mastery are forged.

Matthew Crawford once [described](#) creativity as “a by-product of mastery of the sort that is cultivated through long practice,” rather than freedom from rules or friction. True creativity, he argues, requires dwelling, repetition, and even submission to the slow building of skill. One Assembly participant echoed this:

“[G]enerative AI tools aren't designed...for the people who want to take the journeyman journey of putting in the 10,000 hours to become the master of the craft. The tool is for those who want the shortcut to become the master but will never become the master because they haven't taken that journey... all the little things that we pick up along the way, so the stubbing of a toe or the film camera running out of film in the middle of a shot... these models circumvent that, we don't get to learn... they're never going to produce... the end result that we do as masters of the craft.”

Participants described the long, often painful journey toward skill as the essence of artistry. It builds purpose and confidence into the work. Without it, AI-generated art risks feeling hollow, missing something only the lived experience of making can give. Almost 24% of participants identified personalization as missing from AI systems, underscoring broader sentiments that AI systems are not dialogic enough to the individual rhythms of creatives and artists who want to see how decisions are made, step in to guide them, and feedback results in real time. As participants in one Assembly noted, Miyazaki's reaction to AI- calling it an “*insult to life itself*” was rooted in this fear: that losing process could one day mean losing our ability to engage with the raw experiences of life at all.

Performance stood out as a partial exception. Unlike other creative forms, live art is built on shared presence and risk. These are things technology hasn't (yet) been able to smooth over or automate. As one participant said:

“Technology... is all about efficiency and performance... but then there's performance in the arts... about release and mistakes and creative realness.”

The insight across assemblies was clear: AI might make making faster, but the journey—the friction, the limits, the messy trial-and-error that shape an artist is irreplaceable. Strip that away, and you risk stripping away the depth of creation itself.

2. Simulation is not experience. Tactile interactions are irreplaceable.

Across Assemblies, one point surfaced again and again: AI can mimic the appearance of creativity, but it does not share the conditions that make creativity human. It has no body, no memory shaped by pain or love, no mortality. Its outputs may look like art, but they are detached from the lived experience that gives human stories depth and resonance. Central to the debate was whether AI could ever truly replace human creativity. One participant described how generative AI, in practice, still needs heavy human intervention before it can be used in real creative work:

“I guess I see generative AI as more [of] a tool. I equate it more like VFX than to anything else because to make any of it work or useful in a production setting, it has to be manipulated still. I do a lot of posts, so you're taking a generated image and you're using after effects, you're using sound design still, you are comping it. You're manipulating all the parts just like you would do when you're creating something in a CG environment and in general, I just don't think that a purely AI generated image or thought from an LLM, I think there's just massive deficiencies in them and they very rarely are, they can't imagine the future. The way I think about the AI machine, it doesn't experience gravity, it can't touch something. It's never going to be able to know what it was like to fall in love or to have their heart broken or to graduate from college or graduate from kindergarten or whatever...[S]tub it's toe. So it's just never going to get there. It just isn't. And being worried that it is, I don't know, kind of more stressful than it's worth.”

Others pointed out that human creativity is defined as much by limits and perspective as by imagination. What makes a story powerful is not the sum of all possible information, but what is chosen, omitted, and uniquely experienced:

Participant: ***“You [say] the word scrape, you can't get it out of your head. It gives me this visual of absolutely everything. Giant dump truck, just gathering it all and putting it in a landfill called AI. And I think the nature of creativity, the nature of perspective, what we were talking about earlier is in what you are including and importantly what you are not including. Creativity has edges, it has limits, and sometimes what you decide is not your story is every bit or more important than what is your story and what is any person's story, if it's a good one, if they're the right people to tell it... I think we have to continue to be a society that isn't scraping into one giant container, but it's recognizing multiple conflicting specific ideas of us.”***

Finally, participants noted that even the basic act of transmitting meaning, the flow of ideas and sensations, requires a physical substrate. Without it, information is just abstraction:

Participant: ***“In quantum information theory, there's like a theorem, which is the no cloning theorem. And it's fundamentally impossible to clone information like fundamentally. And it's because like the word information, actually it implies something very deep about it, which is like in formation. It quite literally cannot exist outside of material substrates. Also, like it is inherently tied together. It doesn't exist abstractly, ever.”***

The Assemblies revealed a shared intuition: AI can simulate form, but not the tactile, embodied experience that gives creativity its purpose. Without things like touch, pain, perspective, and presence, there is no real story to tell.

3. Human uniqueness lies in legacy and interpretation.

AI can produce, but it cannot inherit. Human creativity is inseparable from time and culture. Every work we make carries traces of ancestry, lived experience, and shared meaning: an epistemic lineage that no machine can replicate. This surfaced repeatedly across Assemblies as a fundamental distinction between human art and AI outputs.

Participants reflected on transmission as a core part of creative purpose, with two intertwined dimensions. First, simply making something, putting a thought into form, is an act of presence, whether or not it's ever consumed. As one participant put it, creation is a way to say: **“I am here.”** Second, we create to reach others through inspiration or provocation. Creativity, in this sense, is a dialogue between artist and audience, shaped by how the work is received and reinterpreted.

Some artists and creatives spoke of transmission as intergenerational legacy that leaves behind stories that ripple through time:

Participant: ***“I remember when I was a kid, animation spoke to me... it gave me comfort from people and crews who were across the world or in other countries or down the street. It was access that wasn't prevalent. And I think that it is a powerful tool that way. And so it's not only my own self-expression, but it's how can I reach others whether they agree or disagree with whatever the views are, just get thoughts going, whether it's comfort or action or et cetera.”***

Another participant tied this sense of lineage to human cognition itself:

Participant: ***“When we look at our knowledge, our knowledge doesn't start and end with the day we were born and the day we act, our knowledge is something that's shared throughout our past and ancestors. And so we are able to create our way of thinking and our interpretation very differently to AI machines because AI is just created now.”***

Interpretation was seen as inseparable from transmission. Once a creation leaves the artist, it evolves as audiences reframe it and make it their own. This iterative transformation is part of what makes art alive, and part of what's at risk in AI-mediated systems that remix and redistribute without context or consent.

Participants wrestled with how AI alters this lineage in two ways:

- **Upstream:** By taking over the act of materializing a creative thought, AI can blur authorship or pull expression out of the artist's hands.
- **Downstream:** AI-enabled remixing can transform works far beyond the creator's intention, often for profit, without credit or connection to the original meaning.

The conversations drew on history: remixing has always existed. Star Wars was itself a remix of Kurosawa and 1930s serials. But today, participants noted, remixing is industrialized, legally fortified, and designed to concentrate power:

“He was able to build a multi-billion dollar empire based on his remix. Now, the problem with remixing as it exists right now is that there's not a lot of space for someone to come up with an original remix that they're going to retain the rights to... the rights now belong to these multi-million dollar corporations.”

Some took this further, calling copyright a structural barrier to creativity:

“Yeah, I’m anti copyright law. If you ever actually dealt with copyright law you know it’s like not for artists, it’s for capitalists... They paid money to like force Mickey Mouse down your throat, and then they’re going to put you in jail... if you communicate that you saw it.”

Across these discussions, the insight was stark: AI, lacking ancestry, embodiment, and lived time, can generate images or words, but it cannot carry the same weight of human meaning.

4. The role of the artist is shifting from maker to editor, curator, or systems designer.

Only 21.7% of participants surveyed felt that AI was not impacting their creative process at all, while 19.3% felt AI was a cognitive partner and 17.7% felt it helped accelerate and/or make creative work more efficient. Participants noted that AI is fundamentally changing what it means to be an artist. The role is becoming less about originating every element and more about filtering, editing, and shaping meaning from a vast field of generated possibilities. Intentionality and taste have become as crucial as technical skill. One participant with a DJ background described how technology has lowered the barriers to entry for electronic music:

“Okay, everyone’s a DJ now. Is that a bad thing? No, people can express themselves now. The people who do well are masters and true artists. They produce music, they spend a lot of time curating their brand and their message...”

What sets great artists apart, they explained, is no longer just technical mastery but the ability to design experiences and identities that resonate in a crowded, fast-moving culture.

The nature of performance has also evolved. A concert is no longer just a show; it’s part of a wider interaction between artist and audience, shaped by social media and personal branding:

Participant: ***“The performance has become a sort of two-way street. There was a time when you play a show and then someone would ask you for an autograph. Now you play a show and someone wants to take a selfie with you or film the whole thing. The audience member becomes just as important in the performance now to themselves as going to see the performance. So the ritual dynamic I think is evolving.”***

This blurred boundary between creator and audience has expanded the artist's workload. Today's musicians and performers are often expected to be multi-hyphenate creators that make art, edit content, manage brands, produce video, and market themselves.

One participant raised a structural concern: as the space between creator and audience gets smaller, the supporting ecosystem of crew jobs shrinks. While this **"leanness"** can free artists or studios to take more creative risks, it also consolidates labor onto fewer shoulders, destabilizing the infrastructure that once supported large-scale productions.

Across the Assemblies, this shift emerged as a core tension of AI-enabled creativity: artists are no longer just makers. They are increasingly system designers, navigating tools, platforms, and audiences to shape meaning in a rapidly changing creative economy.

5. Creative labor is increasingly precarious and devalued.

Participants repeatedly expressed concern that AI is compounding long-standing pressures on artists and creatives: invisible labor, derivative training data, and the erosion of sustainable careers. The emotional tone was often grief, especially among those in film, music, and media.

One participant described the growing precarity:

"It's become a lot less sustainable for artists to be able to pursue an artistic career if they do not already come from money. The big fear with AI right now is that this is another way to devalue the work of artists... because it is "easy to produce", because "all you got to do is put a bunch of prompts in and generate something out of that".

It means that your value as an artist is going to go down, and it means that it's going to be a lot less sustainable for you to pursue it as a career... Do you know how many gigs I have right now just to be able to sustain my living right now?... Five... And 20 years ago, I could have just been able to live off of one of those gigs."

As we have already seen, many artists see creativity as inseparable from who they are: ***"artists are going to create because it is fundamental to who we are,"*** according to one participant. While art will continue to be made, the real worry is that the ability to earn a living from it will vanish.

A common fear participants voiced about AI was job displacement. Yet paradoxically, the greatest hope expressed was that AI could be used to augment human creativity. This tension, between technology as a tool for expansion and technology as a driver of precarity, ran through every conversation. Shockingly, over 63% of creatives and 75% of technologists do not feel represented by any institution (including guild, studio) in the fight for creative rights in tech. Job displacement emerged as a much stronger worry than intellectual property.

What's therefore clear is that artists and creatives present a united front on the need for a world with more opportunities and possibilities, and the desire to feel like someone is fighting for them.

6. AI challenges the moral and economic logic of creation.

As AI makes content easier and faster to produce, it disrupts the values that underpin creative labor. If something can be made instantly and cheaply, why make it at all? And what principles, beyond speed and efficiency, should guide the future of creative work?

The case of Toonstar, the start-up behind StEvEn & Parker, illustrates this shift. Toonstar's founder [explained](#) how AI is used throughout production, from story development to imagery and dubbing for overseas audiences: "By leaning into the technology, we can make full episodes 80 percent faster and 90 percent cheaper than industry norms."

This logic of optimization spills over into consumption, too:

Participant: ***"Smaller units of time are easier to sell."***

Participant: ***"[N]ow it's very short form...[Y]ou need a hook, you need something to bring somebody in the first three seconds."***

For many creators, this runs counter to why they began making content in the first place. Narrative and story, the deeper pull of creative work, are often sacrificed in favor of speed and scale. As participants repeatedly emphasized, creative purpose sometimes defies market logic; what is meaningful to make is not always what sells, or what algorithms favor.

Participants also questioned the quality of AI-generated work. As one put it:

"I have yet to see a literary piece produced by AI that really kind of, like, touches my soul and or makes me kind of like, contemplate."

While some AI researchers argue that machines will eventually match or exceed human creativity, [current studies](#) suggest otherwise: human-human pairs still outperform both human-AI and AI-AI collaborations in generating diverse, original ideas.

Podcasts like *The Machine Kills* have [pointed out](#) that arguments against AI creativity often rest on “romantic authorship”: the belief that human art has an ineffable value simply because it is human-made. The Assemblies, however, articulated what might constitute this ‘ineffable’ value: the human ability to feel, remember, inherit, limit, and transmit meaning as well as the innate, evolutionary drive to create that no machine can claim.

Still, the tension remains unresolved: AI is reshaping the economics of creativity, but it has yet to answer why we create, or what makes art worth making.

7. Generative AI is the latest development in the trend towards a frictionless world.

AI is accelerating a long-standing trend in technology: removing friction from both how we create and how we consume. This loss of friction feels convenient, but it changes us.

Technology has been steadily erasing physical and cognitive effort for decades, from online shopping to ride-hailing apps. As one participant noted: ***“Even when you think of ordering a car ride share, it’s frictionless. You don’t have to go outside the elements and hail a car or wait or call.”***

Convenience can be liberating, but it also erodes our patience for effort. Another participant described how this shift feels in daily life:

“The loss of the tactile is a part of the frictionless experience. We experience touch less. Apple has the sound effect of a button being pushed [yet] there’s no button being pushed any longer. Maybe we need to have more buttons... I’ll tell you my patience for friction is less than [it] used to be. I get angrier at technology that isn’t instantly giving me what I ask of it... I feel that road rage feeling that people describe. I feel that with buttons that aren’t buttons... and I think that that... is a frictionless addiction that the world has given me.”

AI has now brought this logic to creativity and media consumption. Short-form video feeds and algorithmic recommendation loops keep users scrolling endlessly. A 2024 [review](#) found that 31% of US adults who use social media doomscroll frequently, a figure that jumps to 51% for Gen Z. This behavior has been [linked](#) to anxiety, lower life satisfaction, and weakened engagement with the physical world.

In advertising and platform design, friction is often treated as a flaw to be engineered away. Yet [research](#) suggests that “positive friction”, small pauses, tactile feedback, deliberate steps in a process, can improve human-AI interactions and even lead to healthier, more meaningful engagement. Examples include Tesla's steering wheel alert when autopilot drivers lose focus, or adding tactile responses back into digital tools.

Participants lead with a provocation: if AI is going to keep accelerating and smoothing out every step of creative and cultural experience, how might we design friction back in?

8. AI has the power to randomize...Or homogenize. Machine intelligence is systemic, not sentient.

Across the Assemblies, participants reframed AI as a systemic condition: an infrastructure that shapes creative environments. Its influence is ambient and driven by design choice. Seeing AI this way allowed participants to interrogate how its systems are built, what feedback loops they create, and whose values they carry.

Online, AI output is often [dismissed](#) as “slop” that is cheap, fast, and devoid of perspective. Participants compared the training process to scraping from a global junkyard: a vast pile of data mashed together, in contrast to human creation, which is shaped by deliberate choices and a lifetime of experiences. This ‘junkyard’ aesthetic can create the illusion of objectivity, as though a machine trained on everything knows everything. In reality, the system reflects the perspectives of those who built and trained it.

Research backs this up. A recent [study](#) warns of a “monoculture of knowers”: if AI is treated as a singular, authoritative voice in science or culture, it risks replacing diverse human perspectives with one homogenized point of view, built on hidden assumptions. Another [study](#) found that even with varied training data, generative AI tends toward sameness over time.

And yet, part of AI's appeal is the opposite: the promise of decentralization, weirdness, and unpredictability. Only 20 years ago, *Time* magazine [named](#) “You” its Person of the Year, celebrating YouTube's early power to hand creativity to anyone with time and passion. Back then, *Time* asked with disbelief: “*Who actually sits down after a long day at work and says... I'm going to make a movie starring my pet iguana?*” Today, YouTube is the largest streaming platform in the world, reshaping media production and consumption entirely.

So, will AI push this even further? Could it fuel a new wave of strange, boundary-breaking art? Some participants thought so:

“[W]hen AI art is good, it’s because it’s so [expletive] weird. I feel like a lot of people only see very, very sterile versions of AI art, but when you get deep in it and you’re not on the censored models, the stuff coming out of there is just so far beyond what a person would make. It can be terrifying. You actually make an image and you’re like the FBI could maybe arrest me because of this image...like gore. Really, really weird mutant porn. Really, really just intense, non-human, scary alien shit. But most people don’t see that because it’s been sterilized by platform capitalism to not let you see that...”

This irony is ever present: AI holds the potential to expand creativity into chaotic, unsettling new spaces, yet the systems built around it often drive toward sameness and efficiency. As AI’s generative capacity improves, the question remains whether the structures we build will let it stay weird, or force it to flatten everything into one perspective.

9. Resistance is not rejection, but redesign.

The Assemblies did not argue for rejecting AI outright. Instead, participants imagined how technology could be reframed and rebuilt to reflect creative values rather than override them. Could AI systems embed ethics, friction, curiosity, and care? Could they support sustainable creative economies instead of undermining them?

Across sessions, participants identified opportunities for change. They called for tools that honor human intention, profit models that let artists thrive, and platforms that slow down attention rather than exploit it. A few reflections captured this spirit of optimism and possibility:

Participant: ***“[W]e all have a desire to create that’s not going to be replaced...That’s something that’s distinctly human and will always belong to us. How we capitalize on that and turn it into an ecosystem where people are making money is the question...So I think it’s about finding the balance.”***

Participant: ***“I find that on some intuitive level, friction feels right...there’s something about slowing down things that are too slippery. Actually introducing things that maybe create checkpoints, create the human-in-the-loop effect. When things feel too slippery, make them a little bit harder.”***

Participant: ***“I mean, streaming could be interesting... co-opting streaming and turning it into a very, very creative force... a contemplative way of thinking about streaming flow.”***

The Assemblies made clear that resistance doesn’t mean shutting the door on AI. It means taking back the design process and asking how technology can serve human creativity first and foremost.

V. Hollywood's 8 Rules For AI

From the five Assemblies of artists, performers, technologists, and storytellers, it became clear people felt strongly that **AI needs to work for creativity, not against it**. The Assemblies served as a space for a community to imagine what creativity *is* in a radical new way, and also generate core insights with each other about creativity's relationship to AI. Finally, these insights lead us to the following **8 Rules** for designing technology that sustains, not strips, human imagination.

1. Build For Process, Not Just Output

Design systems that support the *process* of creation not only the production of results. Creativity is not just about efficiency or outcome, but also about discovery, friction, failure, and transformation. AI tools should **support exploration, not shortcut it**.

Example: A24's approach to filmmaking famously allows directors creative freedom and long development periods, resulting in distinctive, award-winning work. In tech, platforms should prioritize features that support iterative exploration and the development of creators' skills and facilities instead of one-click generation. This can mean actively involving creators in the decision-making process by allowing them to give feedback throughout the generation process and by offering multiple input modalities (such as sketches, stills, voice notes, or mood references). On the philanthropic side, funders should support long term grant and fellowship programs focused on skill development.

2. Encourage Randomness and Glitchiness

AI is appealing because its outputs can often surprise us. Creativity thrives at these moments of surprise and wonder. To realize this potential, systems should be designed to encourage artists to be messy and embrace the glitch. This also means investigating what stages of the creative process benefit most from human-AI collaboration and deliberately encouraging training and sampling methods that amplify quirkier, more random outputs. **Don't overdetermine the world.**

Example: AI companies can co-create a creativity model that promotes "glitchiness," or less probable outputs which screenwriters can use as they explore different ideas and pathways for their work. This could be used during the ideation phase of screenwriting, so that screenwriters can "[meander through a latent 'idea space'](#) and curat[e] the model outputs that they find most meaningful." An overdetermined world, on the contrary, is one where Google's "I'm feeling lucky" [disappears](#) altogether, for example.

3. Keep Friction In The Creative Flow

Avoid optimizing creativity into frictionless experiences. Moments of constraint, pain, attention, time pressure, limitation, were repeatedly identified as vital to depth and meaning. Systems should allow for discomfort and limitation. **Design moments that constrain us and make us think.**

Example: Platforms like BeReal intentionally slow down social sharing by allowing only one unedited post a day. Use variables beyond time and clicks to measure audience engagement. User wellbeing, satisfaction, and mental health might push technical implementations towards a slower and constrained experience. Intercept doomscrolling with moments of pause.

4. Protect Lineage and Give Credit

AI tools should not sever creative work from its lineage. Design systems that acknowledge history, context, and cultural origin. Machines borrow from human expression. **AI should trace where its inspirations come from.**

Example: The Adobe Content Credentials focuses on metadata labelling and data provenance for digital content. Embedding traceability at scale could give credit to original creators and communities whose work trains AI. In general, creating chains of context and historicity in content ensures it's never static and divorced from creative community acts.

5. Put Human Purpose at the Center

Design systems that foreground *why* something is being created. Many participants emphasized that AI can replicate form but not purpose. AI should **ask and adapt to creator intent**, making purpose, not just pattern, the starting point.

Example: AI tools should have greater personalization and customizability to each user's intent and specific use case. Canva's design assistant asks users for some measure of intent (poster, ad, invitation) before suggestions.

6. Make AI Transparent and Conversational

Participants described a need for AI systems that are not black boxes. Transparency, in this context, means two things: first, the ability to understand how a model and its levers influence the output; and second, control over those levers. Artists and creatives want to see **how decisions are made, step in to guide them, and feedback results in real time.**

Easily understandable, fine-grain control mechanisms give creators greater agency over the direction and feel of their work.

Application: GitHub Copilot shows its code suggestions in real time, letting developers reject or refine results. Creative AI could do the same for song lyrics, animation frames, or storyboards. AI tools can make control mechanisms like [temperature and guidance](#) more transparent and modifiable through a clear user interface.

7. Value Deliberate Slowness and Depth

Speed should not be the default metric. Participants called for tools that allow space for contemplation and depth. **Design for layered work**, allowing time for ideas to grow instead of forcing instant delivery.

Example: Filmmakers like Terrence Malick famously spend years editing films to find their final form. AI could introduce deliberate checkpoints or time delays to support depth over output velocity.

8. Design for the Whole Creative Ecosystem

Design with the understanding that creativity is relational and systemic, not an isolated capability. This means designing with awareness of how AI systems affect labor, culture, education, ecology, and emotional life. **AI must be built with a *priori* consideration of ecosystem effects**, not as a bolt-on feature.

Example: Creative Commons licensing historically reshaped sharing on the internet by balancing openness and rights. Similar systemic reforms, rethinking licensing, royalties, and attribution in AI training, could protect human creative economies while allowing innovation.

The Takeaway:

Hollywood's creative community isn't asking to roll back AI. They're asking to **redesign it** and to build tools and systems that honor the slow, messy, human work of making meaning. Anything less risks turning culture into 'slop' at scale.

##